When Does Admission Control Pay? Decomposing End-to-End Wall Clock in Memory-Bound Agentic LLM Serving

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***Abstract*—Agentic LLM sessions are long, multi-round jobs whose KV footprint grows every round, and on a memory-constrained accelerator the pool is the binding resource. Admission control therefore looks like the obvious lever: a controller that reads engine telemetry and admits on measured capacity should beat a static cap. We give a measurement that says how much room there is, and show what happens when you build against it. Throughput during busy time is $\overline{R}/\tau$—running requests over per-step cost—so raising concurrency by a factor f buys $f^{1-\epsilon}$, where $\epsilon = \mathrm{d}\ln\tau/\mathrm{d}\ln\overline{R}$. Near zero, added concurrency converts into throughput and any policy that raises it gains; near one it does not, and that is a property of the workload rather than of the controller. We measure ϵ on a memory-bound agentic replay (200 sessions, one 24 GB GPU, a pool that holds four median sessions) and get 0.38 to 0.61 depending on which step cost a system can observe: every 10% of added concurrency buys 4–6% of throughput.**

The verdict that criterion returns here is negative, and we report it at that strength. Nine controller variants spanning four routes, plus a reimplementation of an independent congestion-based controller, none is above the static Pareto front at the latency threshold interactive serving cares about—the best ties it—; a plain cap on resident sessions remains the fastest policy we measured. That is not an argument for admitting everything: with no control at all the median request waits 1,774 seconds for its first token, the prefix cache collapses from a 75% planned hit rate to 1.6%, and SLO falls to 3%. The question is which selective rule, not whether to be selective. The reason our variants fail is two measurable effects rather than one we can tune away: the controllers hold a fifth of the pool idle while sessions queue—their own headroom estimate is 1.77× the truth—and the concurrency they do take is partly paid back in per-step cost. The wall clock splits into busy and idle time; admission policy moves only the running count, and τ rises with it. The idle component (7.4–36.3% of the wall clock) is structural—an agent session issues no request while a tool runs, and that wait averages 16.85 s, not the sub-second figure the trace's median suggests. On device-only configurations we can account for the rise token for token; on host-tier ones we cannot, and we say so. We also report the six of our own claims we retracted along the way, and the boundary of the verdict: at a loose latency threshold one variant does cross the front, by a margin we cannot resolve against run-to-run noise.

***Index Terms*—LLM serving, admission control, KV cache, agentic workloads, performance characterization, negative results**

I. Introduction

An agentic LLM session is not a request. It is a long-lived job that issues a round of inference, waits on a tool, and comes back—tens of times—with a context that grows every round. On a memory-constrained accelerator this makes admission control look like the obvious lever. The KV pool is the binding resource; a single large session can occupy most of it; and the sessions themselves are wildly heterogeneous. If a scheduler can see how much of the pool a candidate will need and how much room is left, surely it should beat a fixed number.

We believed this, built a controller that does exactly that, and spent a considerable amount of GPU time discovering that on our workload and hardware it is false. This paper reports that negative result, but the negative result is not its contribution. Its contribution is a way to know in advance—one number, measurable from logs a serving system already writes, that says how much room admission control has before anyone builds a controller.

A. What we measured

We serve a replay of 200 real coding-agent sessions on a single RTX 3090 (Qwen2.5-Coder-7B, 96K context, SGLang, a 101,432-token KV pool) and compare a family of admission policies against a sweep of static concurrency caps. Nine controller variants, spanning four mechanistically distinct ideas, all land on or below the static Pareto front, and so does a reimplementation of an independent congestion-based controller from the literature (Fig. 1). The best of them reaches the front and no further.

B. Why

We decompose the wall clock into *busy* time, during which the engine has at least one request in flight, and *idle* time, during which it has none. The busy component is governed by $W_{\text{busy}} \approx (G/\overline{R})\,\tau$ (Eq. 3), where $\overline{R}$ is the mean number of running requests, G the generated tokens and τ the per-step cost. An admission policy moves $\overline{R}$, and on our configurations it moves little else—`bres` is the exception, and §III uses it to show why moving both components at once is still not enough. The difficulty is that τ is not constant in $\overline{R}$: it rises from 27.0 to 36.7 ms as the busy-time running count goes from 1.00 to 1.84, and that rise absorbs a third of what the extra concurrency buys.

The idle component is structural rather than a control failure. A session in a tool wait issues no request, so when all live sessions happen to be waiting, the engine is genuinely empty. The stretches are short in the middle and long in the tail—median 5.6 s, mean 20.6 s—and the tail is what a scheduler feels: 69.6% of all idle *time* sits in stretches over 20 s, an order of magnitude above the 2 s control cycle. Crucially, the tool wait itself is much longer than the trace's median suggests:

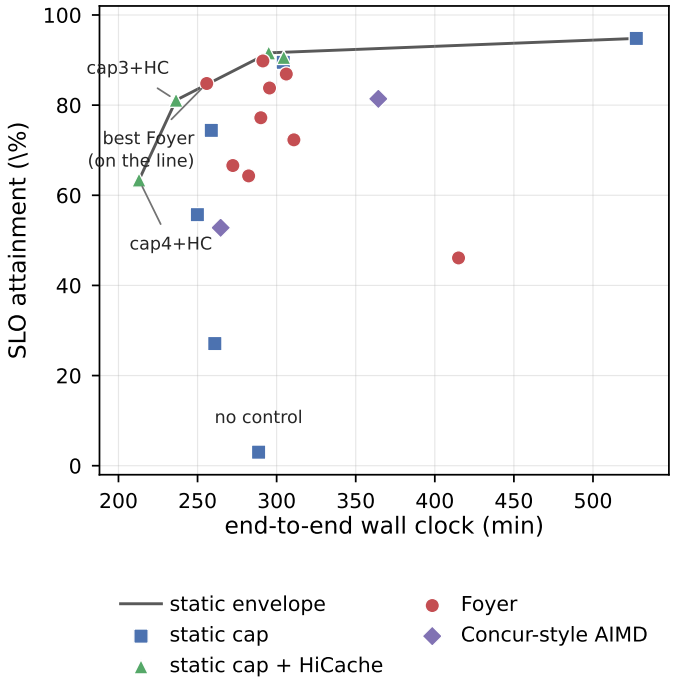


Fig. 1. Every completed run on the (wall clock, SLO) plane. The grey line is the upper-left envelope of the static points; a policy below or on it has not beaten a static cap, because time-slicing two caps approximates any point on the segment between them. Nine Foyer variants plus a reimplementation of an independent controller, none above at the 10 s latency threshold used throughout; §VIII reports how far that verdict is conditional on the threshold.

the median inter-round gap is 0.35 s, but the *mean* is 16.85 s with 22% of gaps over ten seconds. A controller that reads only the median concludes, as we initially did, that sessions never leave and therefore that there is no idle time to recover. There is.

C. Contributions

- We test four routes by which an adaptive admission controller was expected to beat a tuned static cap on this workload, and we are precise about what each one rests on. Two are falsified by measurement against criteria we fixed before the runs—changing the accounting base (§V) and changing the growth reserve. One is a knob rather than a hypothesis, and we report it only because it slides the operating point along the front and adds no mechanism. The fourth, changing the execution granularity from session count to running-request count, is falsified by measurement *and* by an argument about why the permit mechanism cannot express the control it would need. We do not call the last two of these falsifications of a stated hypothesis, because they were not.
- We give a two-part decomposition of the wall clock (§III) that locates the cancellation: admission policy moves the running-request count, and the per-step cost moves with it. On the device-only configurations we can account for that rise token for token—evicted prefixes are recomputed almost one for one—and we report where that account stops: on host-tier configurations the recomputation count is flat while the step cost still moves, and we do not know why (§III).
- We reduce the question to one measurable number, the elasticity of per-step cost with respect to the running count (§IV), and measure it at 0.38 on the model-consistent step cost and 0.61 on the per-request one, on the configurations whose mechanism we can account for token for token. This is the paper's constructive output: it decides in minutes, from logs a serving system already writes, whether admission control has room.
- We characterize when adaptivity *could* have paid, and show that our workload is not that case: the same throttle configuration that is worth $+51\%$ at 25 sessions costs -42% at 200 (§VI). Put differently, no single scalar cap is optimal across both, which is the regime adaptive control exists for. On the low-load tier, where that argument bites hardest, the controller is *not* worse—same-generation measurements put it on the front, $+0.9$ pp above the line and inside the noise. On the high-load tier it is dominated. That asymmetry, not a blanket failure, is what this paper measures.
- We make the measurements reproducible: the verdict of every run is produced by a single script from the raw per-step logs, and we report the six claims we had to retract along the way, with the checks that caught them.

D. What we do not claim

We do not claim that admission control is useless in general. We claim it does not pay *here*, we show the measurement that decides it, and we argue (§IV) that the same measurement can be taken on another workload before committing to a sweep. We also do not claim our hardware and model are representative; our results are from one 24 GB accelerator and one 7B model, and extending them is future work.

II. Background and Setup

A. Workload

We replay 200 coding-agent sessions drawn from the TraceLab corpus [1]. Each session is a sequence of rounds; a round presents a prompt of median 23,187 tokens (p90 51,064; maximum 89,436, which alone is 88% of the KV pool), and between rounds the session waits on a tool before returning with a longer context. Arrivals are Poisson at $\lambda = 0.04\,\mathrm{s}^{-1}$ over an 80-minute window, giving 999 steps in total. Two sessions of maximum size cannot be co-resident: their combined contexts exceed the pool by 76%.

The tool wait is the load's defining property and the one most easily misread. Its *median* is 0.35 s, which invites the conclusion that sessions never leave the engine. Its *mean* is 16.85 s, 22% of waits exceed ten seconds, and the maximum is 300 s. We verified that our replay harness honors the trace faithfully: across 799 round transitions the measured gap is 16.85 s mean against a demanded 15.82 s. On a typical transition the harness adds nothing—the median of the per-transition measured/demanded ratios is 1.001—while the ratio of the two

means is 1.065, the difference sitting in the tail. The corpus's own characterization makes the same point qualitatively—it reports "diverse and heavily-tailed tool calls" and calls these gaps "human-paced"—but gives no numeric mean [1], so the 16.85 s above is our measurement over the released trace, not a figure we quote from that paper.

B. Engine and the binding constraint

We use SGLang v0.5.10 [2] with Qwen2.5-Coder-7B-Instruct [3] extended to 96K context, on one RTX 3090 (24 GB). KV is paged [4]; at `mem-fraction-static` 0.85 the pool is 101,432 tokens. Hierarchical caching (HiCache), with a host tier of twice the device pool, is enabled on the configurations marked *+HC* and on every Foyer run; the five plain static caps run without it. We keep both because the host tier turns out to change the mechanism (§III). Every run is guarded: if the pool does not come out at $101{,}432 \pm 20$—which happens when another tenant holds memory on the card—the run is aborted rather than recorded, because SGLang sizes the pool from free memory at startup and a shrunken pool silently produces incomparable numbers.

The relevant consequence is that the pool holds only about four median sessions. Concurrency is therefore capacity-bound, not scheduler-bound, and this is the premise on which everything below rests.

C. The controller under test

Foyer is an admission controller that reads engine telemetry and issues *named* permits rather than a scalar cap: a session is admitted by appearing in a permit file, and the runner refuses to start a round for a session that is not listed. This design choice matters for the comparison, because it is what allows per-session actions at all—including the pause primitive we exploit in §V-G. It also means that a session, once admitted, holds its permit for its entire lifetime, so the controller never frees capacity by discarding a session's state—it admits fewer sessions instead. That is a statement about the *policy*, not about the memory: the engine's radix cache still evicts parked prefixes under pressure, and we measure that it does and that they are recomputed (§III). We return to this distinction in §VIII, because it bounds how far our negative result generalises.

Each control cycle (2 s) the controller computes

$$\Pi \;=\; \max(\rho, \textstyle\sum_i c_i) \;+\; \sum_i g_i, \tag{1}$$

where ρ is the engine's reported occupancy, c_i the context length of live session i, and g_i its forecast growth over the next `horizon` rounds. A session is admitted when $\Pi + n \le B$, with n the candidate's estimated need and B the budget. The three terms are respectively the measured physical occupancy, a reservation for sessions currently parked in a tool wait (whose KV is evictable and therefore absent from ρ), and a reservation for future growth.

D. Baselines and the verdict criterion

Baselines are static caps: at most N sessions resident, $N \in \{1, \ldots, 5\}$, with and without HiCache. We compare on two axes: end-to-end wall clock (time from the first submission to the last completion) and SLO attainment (fraction of requests whose time-to-first-token is under 10 s).

The verdict criterion deserves care, because "faster than cap-N" is not the question. The question is whether a policy reaches a point *above* the static front. A point that lies merely between two static caps is not a win: mixing cap-N and cap-M by time slice approximates any point on the line between them. We flag this segment argument as an argument, not a measurement—we did not run the time-sliced policies, and carrying queue state and cache contents across a switch could bend the line. It is the criterion we apply, and it is conservative in the direction that matters: it can only make our negative result harder to claim, never easier. So we take the upper-left envelope of the static points and report each controller's signed distance above or below it. We classify a signed distance of more than $+1.0$ pp as above the front, less than -1.0 pp as below it, and the band between the two as *on* it—a tie, not a win. The band is a convention we fixed before running anything, and we report it here because every verdict in this paper depends on it. Our later replicate measurements (§V) bracket it rather than justify it: the SLO spread of configurations we ran more than once ranges from 0.5 pp to 12.2 pp, so for some configurations the band is generous and for others it is far too narrow. We flag this as a weakness of the criterion, not a defence of it. One further property of the envelope deserves flagging, because four of the nine controller variants finish slower than 295 minutes. Its right-hand segment runs from `cap2`+HiCache at 295 minutes to `cap1` at 527, and `cap1` is the only anchor there that runs *without* HiCache. Those four—`hz2`, `bres`, `breshz1` and `foyfix`—are therefore judged against an interpolation between one host-tier point and one device-only point. If the envelope is drawn from the host-tier anchors alone, that segment does not exist and those four cannot be adjudicated at all; drawn from device-only anchors alone, they sit further below. We report the conservative reading and note that the honest statement about those four is *below the front as we defined it*, not *below every static configuration*. Every verdict in this paper is produced by one script from the raw logs, and the script's own first version was wrong—it extrapolated past the end of the envelope and declared the slowest static cap a winner. We fixed it and report the episode because it is the failure mode this criterion is most prone to.

III. Decomposing the Wall Clock

A. Two components

We split the wall clock at every sampled instant according to whether the engine has any request in flight:

$$W \;=\; W_{\text{busy}} \;+\; W_{\text{idle}}. \tag{2}$$

Fig. 2 shows the split for every completed run. Two things are immediately visible and both matter later.

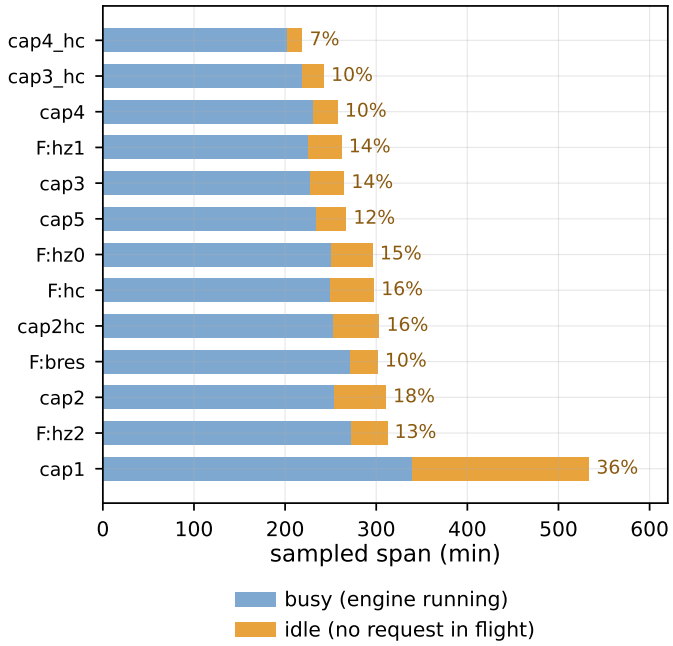


Fig. 2. Wall clock split into busy and idle for every completed run, ordered by total duration. Idle is 7.4% for the fastest configuration and 36.3% for the slowest. Note `bres`: it cuts idle to 10.1% and is still slower than its own baseline, because busy time grows instead.

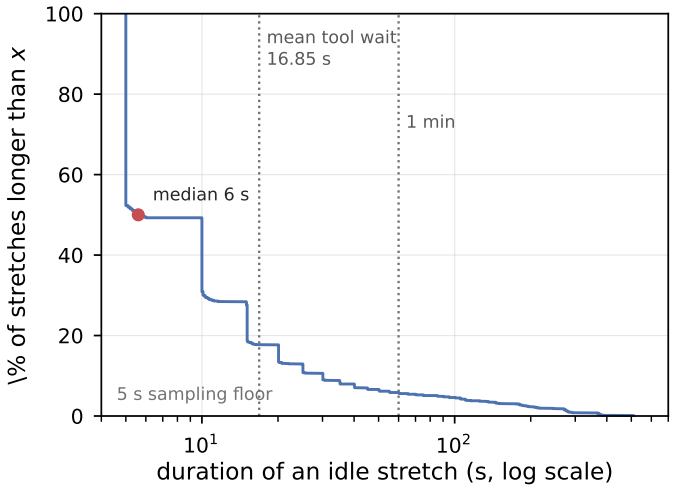


Fig. 3. Survival function of idle-stretch duration, pooled over all completed runs (1,849 stretches). Most stretches are short—the median is 5.6 s—but the minutes are not: 69.6% of all idle *time* sits in stretches longer than 20 s, and the mean stretch is 20.6 s, the same order as the 16.85 s mean tool wait. The cliff is the 5 s sampling floor.

First, idle time is not noise. It ranges from 7.4% of the wall clock for the fastest configuration to 36.3% for the slowest, and it is not spread evenly. Over 1,849 stretches the median is 5.6 s—close to the 5 s sampling floor, because most tool calls are quick—but 17.6% of them exceed 20 s, the 90th percentile is 30.1 s, and the longest is 511 s (Fig. 3). The tail, not the middle, is what a scheduler feels, and it sits at the scale of the 16.85 s mean tool wait.

Second, the two components move independently. `bres` (§V) reduces idle from 15.9% to 10.1%, recovering about 17 minutes—and is nonetheless *slower* than its own baseline, because its busy time grows by 21 minutes. Any account that treats "more concurrency" as one thing will get this wrong.

B. What determines busy time

During busy time the engine executes steps; each step produces one token per running request. Hence

$$W_{\text{busy}} \approx \frac{G}{\overline{R}}\tau, \tag{3}$$

with G the total generated tokens (fixed by the trace at 706,010) and τ the per-step cost. Across our runs τ is not a fit parameter we tuned; we obtain it two independent ways, and reporting both is what shows they are measuring different things rather than confirming each other.

a) Method 1 (derived).: $\tau_1 = W_{\text{busy}} \cdot \overline{R}/G$. Two choices in that expression are easy to get wrong and both matter. The time term must be the *busy* component, not the wall clock—using the wall clock charges idle time to the steps. And $\overline{R}$ must be the mean running count *during busy time*, not the mean over the whole run: the whole-run mean includes the idle samples, where the count is zero, so it equals $\overline{R}_{\text{busy}} \times$ (busy fraction). Using it makes τ_1 too low by exactly the busy fraction—36.3% for `cap1`, whose idle share is 36.3%. We report both columns in the data, and use the busy-conditional mean throughout; the whole-run mean is what an earlier revision of this paper used, and it made the two methods agree far better than they do.

b) Method 2 (independent).: For each step record we compute the per-request decode interval, $(\text{total_duration} - \text{first_token})/(\text{output_len} - 1)$, and take the median over steps with $\text{output_len} \geq 32$.

The two do not agree exactly, and the disagreement is informative rather than embarrassing. τ_1 exceeds τ_2 on every run, by 8–40%, and the gap is the share of engine steps that are prefill and therefore emit no output token: τ_1 averages over all steps, τ_2 measures only the decode interval. That share comes out at 15–28% across the five device-only configurations, which is the right order of magnitude for a workload whose prompts are 23,k tokens median against sub-1,k outputs. So the two are not two estimates of one number; they are measurements of two different things, and we now say so. Fig. 4 shows both, run by run. Method 2 remains the one that does not depend on the quantity it is used to explain, and it is the one we quote when the question is the cost of a decode step. The engine's own latency counters (`itl_p50`, `e2e_p50`, `ttft_p50`) are exported as zero by SGLang v0.5.10 in our configuration, so no directly measured step time exists in our data; instrumenting this is future work.

C. The per-step cost is not constant in concurrency

Equation 3 would be uninteresting if τ were a constant. It is not. Across our 13 runs τ_1 ranges from 27.0 to 36.7 ms and τ_2 from 20.6 to 33.1 ms, and both rise with the running count: fitting Eq. 4 to the five device-only configurations gives

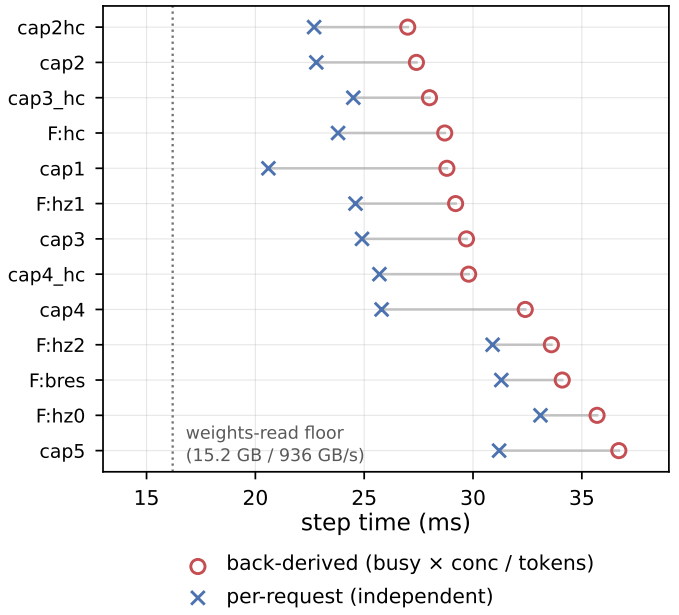


Fig. 4. Per-step cost by two independent measurements, one run per row: circles are model-consistent (all engine steps), crosses are the per-request decode interval. They do not agree—τ_1 exceeds τ_2 by 8–40%— and the gap is the prefill share, not measurement error. The dotted line is the cost of reading the weights once; every run sits above it.

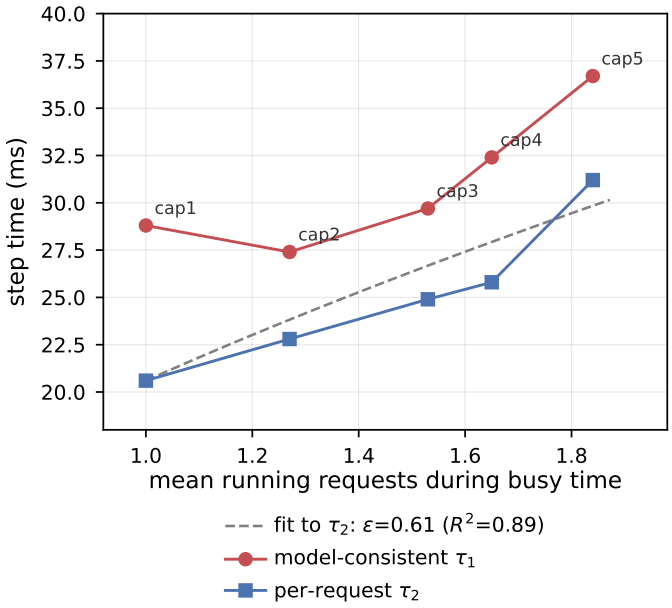


Fig. 5. Per-step cost against the running count during busy time, for the five device-only configurations. Two measurements: τ_1 is model-consistent (it averages over all engine steps, including prefill that emits no output token), τ_2 is the per-request decode interval. The fitted exponent is the elasticity ε of Eq. 4, and τ_1 exceeds τ_2 by 8–40%—that gap is the prefill share.

$\varepsilon = 0.38$ for τ_1 and 0.61 for τ_2 ($R^2 = 0.89$ for the latter, Fig. 5).

The relation is a trend, not a law. Two host-tier configurations with similar running counts behave differently: `cap4_hc` runs 1.73 requests at 29.8 ms while `F:hz0` runs 1.66 at 35.7 ms. Running count sets a floor and a trend, not a value—and on the host-tier family, as we show below, it does not set the value at all.

This is the crux of the paper, and we state it at the strength the arithmetic supports. Hold τ_1 at its value for `cap1`, 28.8 ms, and busy time falls as $1/\overline{R}$: raising the running count from 1.00 to 1.84 should have cut busy time by a factor of 1.84, from 340 minutes to 184. The measured curve flattens and lands at 234. The rise in τ takes back 50 of the 156 minutes that the extra concurrency would otherwise have bought—*a third* of the gain, not all of it and, as an earlier revision of this paper claimed, not more than half. The other two thirds are real: raising concurrency does make the engine faster. What it does not do is make it faster in proportion, and the shortfall compounds with every controller that tries to exploit the difference.

a) What the engine is doing when it is not decoding.: SGLang exposes two counters that answer this directly: tokens evicted from the radix cache, and prompt tokens that had to be prefilled rather than reused. Across the five static caps *without* HiCache the two track each other almost exactly. `cap1` evicts 9.2 M tokens and prefills 8.6 M uncached; `cap5` evicts 21.3 M and prefills 20.7 M; the gap is 0.6–0.7 M on every one of the five. An evicted prefix is recomputed, close to one token for one, and that recomputation is chunked into decode steps. Those same five runs give a monotone relation between recomputation and τ: 8.6 M uncached tokens at 18.4 ms, 9.2 at 22.4, 11.5 at 25.5, 15.4 at 29.0, 20.7 at 32.2. That is a mechanism consistent with the τ trend on all five device-only configurations. It is five points on five different policies, not an intervention: we did not hold concurrency fixed and vary eviction, so we call it consistent rather than demonstrated.

b) Where the mechanism stops.: With HiCache enabled the correspondence breaks—and it breaks in a way that confirms the mechanism rather than undermining it. The device cache misses as much as before: `cap4_hc` misses 22.4 M tokens on the device, more than the device-only `cap4` misses. But only 9.1 M of that is recomputed; the other 13.3 M is served from the host tier. Across the eight host-tier runs the host serves 13–19 M tokens each, and across the five device-only runs it serves *exactly zero*—the device miss equals the recomputed count to within rounding on all five. Recomputation is still what the device cannot absorb; the host tier is a second absorber in front of it.

That does not resolve the Foyer family, and we say so plainly. Those runs sit at a flat 8.6–8.7 M recomputed tokens while τ ranges from 22.5 to 30.6 ms. Whatever moves τ there is not recomputation, and we do not know what it is. We flag it as the largest open question in the paper, and note that the negative result does not rest on it: the cancellation is measured directly, not inferred from the mechanism.

c) A refutation we had to withdraw.: An earlier revision withdrew this mechanism outright, on two checks that were both wrong. The first was that total prefilled tokens equalled

the trace's planned prefill to a ratio of 1.00, so no token could have been computed twice. `prompt_tokens_total` counts the full submitted prompt *including* its cached portion, so it equals the sum of prompt lengths by construction and cannot detect recomputation; the quantity that can is the uncached count used above, which varies by 2.4× across these runs. The second was that SGLang reported no retractions. Radix-cache eviction is not a retraction—retractions count running requests preempted mid-flight, a different event with its own counter. We record the episode because it is the same failure mode as the segment argument of §II: a check that looks like a measurement but is an identity.

D. Why idle time exists, and why recovering it does not pay

Idle time is a property of the workload, not of the controller. A session in a tool wait holds its permit and its KV but issues no request; with only about two live sessions, the probability that all of them are simultaneously waiting is substantial. The direct evidence is the duration of the stretches themselves: they are of the same order as the tool waits, and an order of magnitude longer than the 2 s control cycle (Fig. 3). A controller cannot be blamed for a gap that is set by the tool.

We note one claim we had to drop here. An earlier draft reported that idle fraction falls monotonically with mean concurrency. With the full data it does not: `F:hz0` at 1.41 running requests idles 15.2% while `cap4` at 1.48 idles 10.4%. The weaker statement that survives is the one we use—the stretches are structural and long.

The obvious remedy—keep more sessions live so that someone is always ready—is what `bres` does. It works in the narrow sense: `bres` recovers about 17 of the minutes that its own baseline spends idle. It is still slower overall, because the sessions it keeps live raise the step cost by more than the recovered idle is worth. Idle is not unrecoverable; it is recoverable at a price that is not worth paying here. The structural remedy would be to make the engine do work during a wait, but there is no work to do: the session's next round does not exist until its tool returns.

IV. A Criterion for When Admission Control Can Pay

The decomposition turns the question into one number. Throughput during busy time is $\overline{R}/\tau$, so raising concurrency by a factor f buys a factor $f^{1-\epsilon}$, where

$$\epsilon \;=\; \frac{\mathrm{d}\ln\tau}{\mathrm{d}\ln\overline{R}} \tag{4}$$

is the elasticity of per-step cost with respect to the running count. At $\epsilon = 0$ the step cost is flat, concurrency converts one for one into throughput, and an admission controller has room to work. At $\epsilon = 1$ the two cancel exactly and it has none. Everything in between is a quantitative statement about how much room.

On the five device-only configurations, where §III establishes that the step cost is driven by recomputation, $\overline{R}_{\text{busy}}$ runs from 1.00 to 1.84. A least-squares fit of Eq. 4 over those five points gives $\epsilon = 0.61$ on the per-request measurement ($R^2 = 0.89$), or 0.38 on the model-consistent one (Fig. 5). The practical reading is that every 10% of added concurrency buys roughly 4–6% of throughput, depending on which step cost you can measure. That is a statement about what added concurrency is worth on this workload. It is *not* a proof that a controller must lose—a controller could still win by raising concurrency at times a fixed cap does not—so we report it alongside the measurements of §V, not instead of them. We offer ϵ as a diagnostic, with a caveat we would rather state than bury. On our data it is computed from the same wall clock the model then explains—τ_1 is derived from W_{busy}, so using it to predict W_{busy} restates rather than tests—and its five points are five different policies, so the slope is a cross-policy association, not a transportable causal derivative. τ_2 is genuinely independent of the wall clock but measures only decode, so it cannot be dropped into a throughput equation that includes prefill. What survives is a comparison tool on a single workload: the elasticity says how quickly per-step cost eats added concurrency *here*, and it can be computed from two runs before committing to a sweep. Whether it orders *different* workloads the way it orders concurrency on this one is untested, and we do not claim it. It is not, as an earlier draft of this paper claimed, something that decides the question in minutes before building anything.

V. Results: Four Routes, One Outcome

A. The frontier

Fig. 1 places every completed run on the (wall clock, SLO) plane and draws the upper-left envelope of the static points. Table I gives the numbers and each controller's signed distance from that envelope.

The result is unambiguous. Of nine controller variants, none is above the envelope. The best, a growth-reserve setting of one round instead of the default three, lands $+0.22$ percentage points above the line—and we measured how large a margin means nothing. The answer is uncomfortable for our own method. Three configurations were run more than once, and while their wall clocks are stable across repeats—coefficients of variation of 0.9%, 1.6% and 1.8%—their SLO is not: the ranges are 5.1, 1.0 and 0.5 pp. The widest of those belongs to an *envelope anchor*: `cap4`+HiCache scores 63.4% on one run and 68.5% on its repeat. So the front we measure against is not a sharp line, and our ± 1.0 pp verdict band is narrower than the uncertainty of the points that define it. Against that, the best controller's $+0.22$ pp is not merely inside the noise—it is smaller than the noise of the anchors by an order of magnitude. We record it as *on* the line rather than above it, and we state plainly that resolving a margin this small would need several repeats per configuration, which we did not run.

The same repeat moved the frontier and changed nothing. The leftmost anchor's second run came out both faster (209.1 against 213.0 minutes) and higher on SLO (68.5 against 63.4), so it displaces the first as the envelope's leftmost point. Not one controller verdict moves: every one of them finishes to the right of the next anchor at 236 minutes, so none of them is

judged against the segment that changed. We report both runs rather than keeping the better one, because a frontier whose anchors are single measurements is the weakness this whole subsection is about.

The other end of the front deserves its own sentence, because the rest of this paper is negative and a reader could close it thinking the answer is to do nothing. The run with *no* admission control—every session admitted the moment it arrives—finishes in 288.6 minutes at 3.0% SLO, 87.5 pp below the envelope and the worst result we report by a factor of three. Its median time-to-first-token is 1,774 seconds, its prefix cache hit rate collapses from the trace's planned 75.5% to 1.6%, and its segment SLO is 30% in the first tenth of the run and exactly zero in each of the nine after that. Uncontrolled admission does not degrade gracefully; it destroys the cache and then serves almost nobody. The question this paper addresses is therefore not whether to admit selectively, but which selective rule to use.

Two features of the front are worth noting before the negative results. The envelope is steep between 213 and 236 minutes (0.76 pp per minute) and shallow thereafter (0.18 pp per minute), so the cost of buying SLO by retreating from the fast end is high. And W is not monotone in concurrency: five sessions (260.9 min) is *slower* than four (249.9 min)—the same configuration family, no host cache on either side—because the per-step cost rises faster than the request count does. We return to this non-monotonicity in §III, where it turns out to be the first appearance of the mechanism that drives the whole frontier.

B. The controllers leave memory unused

Before the routes, one measurement that reframes all of them. Our controller keeps every session's permit for its lifetime, so its pool occupancy is a policy output, not a constraint. It runs at a median of 49.2% of the pool on the base configuration, and the median number of sessions queueing for admission is 66. The configuration that finishes fastest, a static cap of four with the host tier, runs at 70.2%. The ordering is the same across every arm we have: occupancy, then running requests, then wall clock.

The controller believes it is nearly full. Its own decision log records the projection it admits against—the largest of measured occupancy and the summed contexts of live sessions, plus a reserve for their growth—at a median of 89,073 tokens against a budget of 96,360, i.e. 7% free. Its measured occupancy at the same instants is 49,905 tokens, i.e. 46% free. The projection is 1.77× the truth. Two terms produce the gap: charging every live session its full context, when a parked session's KV is evictable and therefore absent from the engine's count, and the growth reserve, which alone is 26,762 tokens, 28% of the budget.

Two things follow, and we are careful about the second.

The first is that the controllers under-use the pool, and that this is a property of their estimates rather than of the hardware: the base configuration holds a fifth of the pool idle with 66 sessions queued, because it believes it has 7% free when it has 46%. Any account of why it is slow that does not mention this is incomplete.

TABLE I

ALL COMPLETED RUNS. *Conc.* IS THE TIME-WEIGHTED MEAN NUMBER OF *live* SESSIONS, WHICH IS NOT THE RUNNING-REQUEST COUNT $\overline{R}$ USED IN §III—A LIVE SESSION IS PARKED IN A TOOL WAIT MOST OF THE TIME, SO `cap5` SHOWS 4.89 LIVE AGAINST 1.84 RUNNING. Δ IS THE SIGNED DISTANCE FROM THE STATIC ENVELOPE AT THAT WALL CLOCK; ABOVE $+1.0$ PP COUNTS AS A WIN, BELOW -1.0 PP AS A LOSS, AND THE BAND BETWEEN AS A TIE (§II). THREE CONTROLLER RUNS STOPPED 1–4 STEPS SHORT OF 999 (`hz0` 995, `hz2` 997, `rg4` 998); THEY ARE LISTED WITH THEIR MEASURED VALUES AND NOT TREATED AS FULL RUNS.

Policy	Wall (min)	Conc.	SLO (%)	Δ (pp)
Static caps				
no control	288.6	1.69	3.0	−87.45
cap1	527.4	1.00	94.8	*anchor*
cap2	304.2	1.99	89.5	−2.23
cap3 (fixed)	258.7	2.89	74.4	−10.70
cap4	249.9	3.94	55.7	−27.82
cap5	260.9	4.89	27.1	−58.39
Static caps + HiCache				
cap2+HC	295.0	1.99	91.6	*anchor*
cap3+HC	236.4	2.93	81.1	*anchor*
cap4+HC	213.0	3.93	63.4	−6.90
cap4+HC (repeat)	209.1	3.87	68.5	*anchor*
Foyer controller variants				
horizon=1	255.8	2.58	84.8	+0.22
horizon=3 (base)	291.3	2.06	89.8	−1.14
horizon=2	306.1	2.22	86.9	−4.85
resident base	295.5	2.40	83.8	−7.81
horizon=0	290.0	2.69	77.2	−13.50
horizon=1, no hw	310.9	2.77	72.3	−19.52
no gate, no resv.	272.3	3.25	66.6	−20.93
running gate=4	282.3	3.03	64.3	−25.02
all throttles off	415.0	2.58	46.1	−47.15
Independent adaptive controller (§V-F)				
AIMD, paper params	364.3	1.91	81.4	−11.15
AIMD, retuned	264.6	3.87	52.8	−33.35

The second is that under-use does *not* order the outcomes, so it is not the whole explanation either. `horizon=1` and `cap3`+HiCache sit at the same median occupancy (57.8% of the pool) and the same mean running count (1.31 against 1.36), and the cap is 19 minutes faster. `hz0` runs at 64.1%, higher than that cap, and is 54 minutes slower. Occupancy buys running requests reliably—the two columns in `occupancy.csv` track each other across all twenty arms—but converting running requests into wall clock is where the per-step cost of §III does its work. Both effects are real; on this workload the unused-memory one is larger for the arms that finish worst, and the step-cost one is what separates the arms that finish close together.

C. Route 1: the accounting base

Our controller's projection (Eq. 1) charges a session for its full context even while it is parked in a tool wait, when its KV is evictable and therefore absent from the engine's reported occupancy. We argued this was a double charge and removed it, admitting on engine telemetry alone.

The charge is not double. Removing it did admit more—engine occupancy rose from 41.0% to 52.2% of the pool—and the round-1+ prefix hit rate held at 80.8% against 80.6%, so no eviction spiral occurred. But the run was 4.2 minutes *slower* and lost 6.0 pp of SLO. Per §III, the extra occupancy raised both $\overline{R}$ and τ (31.3 ms against 23.8 ms), and the two cancelled.

We note that this claim had already been falsified once by source inspection: SGLang's `token_usage` subtracts evictable blocks, so a parked session's prefix is genuinely not counted, and charging for it reserves capacity that really will be needed back. The end-to-end measurement agrees with the source reading.

D. Route 2: the growth reserve

Sessions grow by roughly 2.5K tokens per round, so the controller reserves capacity for the next `horizon` rounds. We swept the horizon over $\{0, 1, 2, 3\}$ and the reserve is not a free parameter to be minimised: Fig. 6 shows the response is non-monotone. Removing the reserve entirely costs 13.5 pp of SLO, and a reserve of two rounds is 15 minutes *slower* than three. The optimum is at one round, and there it touches the static front and stops.

E. Route 3: the hard ceiling

Lowering the budget fraction is the crudest available knob and behaves as the other routes do: it slides the operating point along the front. We report it only for completeness, since it adds no mechanism.

F. An independent adaptive controller

Every controller above is ours, which invites the objection that the negative result is a statement about one design rather than about adaptive admission. We therefore implemented a second, mechanistically different controller: an AIMD window over an agent-level admission set, following the control law of the congestion-based system we compare against in §VII. The window grows additively while cache occupancy sits below a low watermark, is cut multiplicatively when occupancy exceeds a high watermark *and* the prefix hit rate falls below a threshold, and holds otherwise. Cuts pause the youngest sessions at their next step boundary; growth resumes paused sessions first. Every input is a runtime gauge—occupancy and hit rate from the engine, nothing from the trace—and the window acts through the same named permits as Foyer.

It does not beat the static front either, at either parameter setting (Table I). At the values reported in that paper's evaluation it finishes in 364.3 minutes at 81.4% SLO, 11.2 pp below the envelope; the same arm with its retuned watermarks finishes in 264.6 minutes at 52.8%, 33.4 pp below. The retuned setting also has the second-worst segment-to-segment volatility of any run we report (SD 13.2 pp of SLO, with segment values swinging between 37 and 72; only the Foyer-`all-off` arm is worse, at 14.4), which is what a control loop oscillating around a capacity cliff looks like.

We report two things honestly about this comparison. First, this is our reimplementation of a published control law, not the authors' system, and a reimplementation of any controller can underperform its paper. We built it to the published law, gave it the same permit interface and the same 2 s cycle as Foyer, and did not tune it beyond the two documented settings; but the caveat stands. Second, both controllers stall. At its paper parameters this one pinned its window at one session, admitted nothing, and left the engine idle for over an hour. Our own controller does the same thing more briefly: in 4 of the 11 Foyer runs an audit found a single window of 150–175 s in which the engine was empty, the queue held 90 sessions, the SLO valve was open, and the controller issued no permit at all—about 0.9% of each run's wall clock. The remaining runs, including the best one, show no such window. Nothing is logged as an error and the run recovers on its own.

We traced one such window in a repeat of our best configuration and found a code path that explains it: single-flight admission considered only the head of the FIFO queue, and when the head was a session too large to fit the remaining budget it was never admitted, never left the queue, and blocked every smaller session behind it. We fixed that (scan the queue, still admit at most one per cycle), but we are explicit that this is *a* path, not a proven cause: the audit is a log signature, and the same signature can be produced by other closed gates. What we can say is that the signature is present in a third of our Foyer runs and absent from all of our static caps, which have no admission decision to get stuck in.

That is the honest version of a finding we first reported too strongly. An intermediate draft of this paper called it a deadlock and said the configuration that produced our best result was the one that deadlocked on its repeat. Neither holds: the windows are 160 s and self-clearing, and the best configuration never showed one. The windows are also too small (0.9%) to move any verdict we report. We keep them because the mechanism is real and its size is the point: on a pool that holds four median sessions, a controller's failure mode is a silent stall, not graceful degradation, and it took a repeat run to see it.

G. Route 4: execution granularity

The first three routes all assume that what a controller can set is *how many sessions are resident*. A static cap sets the same quantity, so it is unsurprising that they land in the same place. The fourth route attacks the assumption instead: because a large fraction of live sessions are parked at any instant, a cap on *resident* sessions leaves the engine idle whenever all residents happen to be parked. Capping the *running-request* count instead should keep the engine busy while leaving the resident count high.

The permit design supports this directly: a paused session finishes its current round and blocks before its next one, and resumes when the controller re-admits it. We implemented it as a gate on the engine's own `num_running_reqs` and swept the gate over $\{2, 4\}$.

It does not work, and the reason is structural rather than a tuning matter. Since a live session is running about 45% of the time, the running count is approximately $0.45 \times$ (live count).

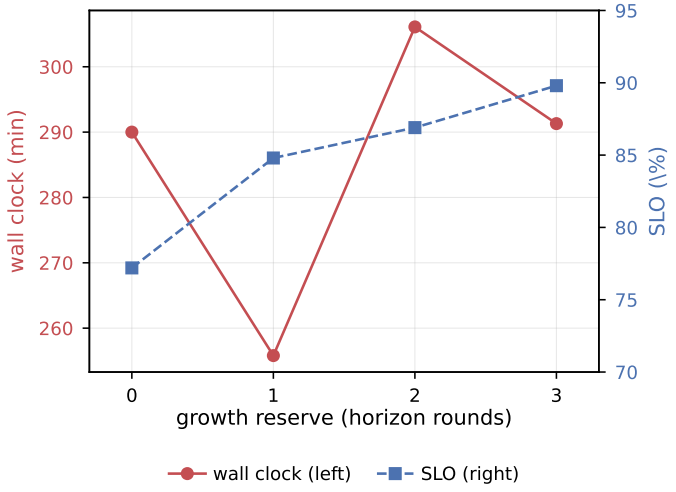


Fig. 6. The growth reserve is not a free parameter. Removing it costs 13.5 pp of SLO; two rounds is 15 minutes slower than three. The optimum at one round touches the static front and does not cross it.

Constraining the live count to N therefore constrains the running count to $0.45N$, which is below the gate—so the gate can only throttle, never pin. Both repairs fail: without a constraint on admission, a paused session is re-admitted on the next cycle and blocks for at most one 2 s cycle; with one, the policy is a session cap again. The obstacle is granularity—`paused` takes effect at round boundaries, while pinning an instantaneous count requires control the permit mechanism does not have.

The measured outcome matches: the gate drove running concurrency from 1.42 to 1.29 and live sessions from 2.78 to 1.91. It tightened rather than pinned, and a tightening is another cap.

VI. Load Dependence

A negative result about adaptivity invites the obvious objection: adaptivity pays when conditions *change*, and a single stationary trace is the one case where a static cap should be near-optimal. We agree, and we test it.

We run the same controller and the same cap family on a 25-session tier. The throttle configuration is reversed: with all safety throttles disabled, the 25-session tier runs *51% faster* (58.4 to 28.8 minutes) at a cost of only 2.4 pp of SLO, while on the 200-session tier disabling the same throttles costs 42% (291.3 to 415.0 minutes) and 43.7 pp of SLO. One switch, two regimes, opposite signs, both around 40–50% (Fig. 7). No single scalar setting is optimal across both.

This is the regime in which adaptive control should win, and we now have the same-generation measurement that earlier drafts of this paper were missing. Four arms on the 25-session tier, all under the current harness (Table II): static caps of two, three and four finish in 32.4, 24.2 and 23.6 minutes at 92.8%, 91.2% and 79.2% SLO, and Foyer finishes in 27.6 minutes at 92.8%.

The finding is a trade, not a defeat, and it is the opposite of what the 200-session tier shows. Against the same-generation

TABLE II
THE 25-SESSION TIER, ALL FOUR ARMS UNDER THE CURRENT HARNESS. THIS IS THE SAME-GENERATION COMPARISON EARLIER DRAFTS OF THIS PAPER WERE MISSING; `cap4` AND THE FOYER ARM WERE RUN FOR THIS REVISION.

Policy	Wall (min)	Conc.	SLO (%)	Seg. SD (pp)
cap2	32.4	1.95	92.8	11.0
cap3	24.2	2.77	91.2	5.1
cap4	23.6	3.39	79.2	21.4
Foyer	27.6	2.47	92.8	7.1

envelope—which runs from `cap4` at (23.6, 79.2) through `cap3` at (24.2, 91.2) to `cap2` at (32.4, 92.8)—Foyer sits $+0.9$ pp above the line. A static cap of three is still 12% faster in wall clock, but it gives up 1.6 pp of SLO to do it, so neither dominates the other. On this tier the controller is a different point on the front rather than a dominated one, which is exactly what the 200-session tier denies it.

We are careful about the size, and about the yardstick. $+0.9$ pp is measured against a straight-line interpolation between static points, not against a switching policy anyone ran, so the defensible statement is that Foyer is not dominated by any static point we measured on this tier—not that it beats what a static mix could achieve. On 125 requests one request is worth 0.8 pp, so the margin is about one request. The tier's segment-to-segment SD (5.1 to 21.4 pp) is not the right yardstick: segment volatility is not run-to-run uncertainty. The right one is the replicate spread we have, 1.0 and 0.5 pp of SLO on the two configurations we repeated, and against that $+0.9$ pp is about a replicate wide. What we will defend is the weaker claim: on the low-load tier the controller is not worse, and the same switch that is worth $+51\%$ there costs -42% at high load. A controller that is competitive where load is light and dominated where load is heavy is the pattern this paper set out to explain, and it is the pattern we measured.

The second finding is the more useful one. The signal an adaptive controller would need is available—the number of sessions waiting for admission differs by 6–7$\times$ between the tiers (median 9–11 at 25 sessions against 66 at 200, maximum 135)—but its *interpretation* is not obvious. At the 25-session tier the controller holds eleven sessions back while running exactly one; that backlog is manufactured by the throttling itself rather than evidence that demand has slackened. Reading it correctly requires combining instantaneous backlog with progress through the run, which is a stateful computation a cap cannot perform. We regard this as the most promising direction we did not finish, and we are explicit that we did not finish it.

VII. Related Work

a) Admission and scheduling for agentic serving.: Recent systems report large gains from treating an agent session, rather than a request, as the schedulable unit, and from preserving session state across tool calls: session-aware admission with CPU-restorable KV [5], [6], program-level

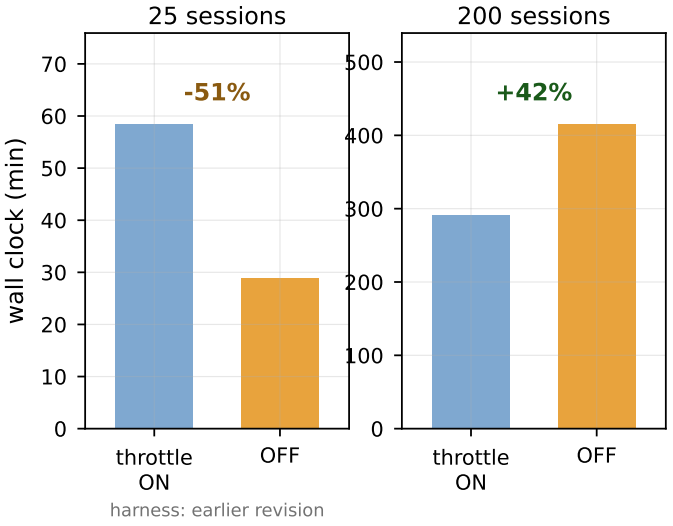


Fig. 7. The same throttle switch, two load tiers, opposite signs. The 25-session bars are from an earlier harness revision and are shown as a direction, not a magnitude—the current-harness 25-session comparison is in Table II instead. The 200-session bars are current.

pause/resume with shortest-context-first restoration [7], and congestion-based control over an agent-level window [8]. A recurring measurement in this line is that recomputation, not admission, dominates: [8] attributes 49.1% of end-to-end latency to recomputation, and [9] preserves state on the CPU at the cost of a reload. Our results are consistent with this literature rather than in tension with it, and §VIII explains why: the mechanism these systems add is one our controller already has.

b) Engine-side techniques.: A separate line improves the engine rather than the admission decision. Iteration-level batching and paged KV [4], [10] are the substrate every policy here runs on; chunked prefill with stall-free batching [11], prefill/decode disaggregation [12], and cache-centric scheduling [13] are the refinements. Our §III attributes 11–20 ms of each 27–37 ms step to work that is not decoding—prefill share and non-decode overhead—which is exactly what this line attacks. We expect these techniques to move the frontier rather than to decide who sits above it, but we did not run the interaction and so state it as an expectation.

c) State retention and preemption.: A third line keeps session state alive across the gaps we measure in §III: keeping KV on cheaper storage across turns [14], [15], migrating it between instances [16], and preempting at iteration granularity [17]. These systems exercise finer control than our 2 s admission cycle, which is the boundary of our negative result: we falsify one control granularity, not the family. What they share with Foyer is that the state is not discarded—which is why, as we argue below, adding admission intelligence on top buys nothing here.

d) Application-level dependencies and replay.: Serving an LLM *application* rather than a request means the scheduler sees dependencies between calls [18], and agentic traces have structure that request-level benchmarks do not capture [19]. Our replay preserves that structure but fixes it in advance, which is exactly the limitation these works would press on.

e) Prefix caching.: The prefix cache is often proposed as the signal an admission policy should use. In our workload it is not a policy variable: round-1+ hit rate tracks the trace's own planned value (80.9%) to within 1.1 pp across four different admission policies—80.6% on the Foyer baseline against 78.5% for the worst static cap—so admission moves it hardly at all. We note the boundary of this claim—we varied admission policy, not eviction policy, and SGLang exposes alternate eviction policies we did not test. A characterization of production KV-cache traffic at a large cloud provider finds that eviction-policy design is "highly workload-dependent" and that reuse patterns differ sharply by request category [20]; that is reason to expect a single trace family to understate the space, though it is not a policy comparison and we do not present it as one.

VIII. Discussion

a) Why published gains do not reappear.: The systems cited above win by keeping session state alive across tool waits and by pausing at agent granularity rather than request granularity. Foyer has both properties by construction: the permit file gives per-session pause and resume, and the controller never frees capacity by discarding a session—it admits fewer sessions instead. To that extent the mechanism these systems add is one our controller already has, which is one reason adding admission intelligence on top of it buys nothing here.

We are careful not to overstate this, because the distinction is between *choosing* to discard state and *having* it evicted. Retention here is the engine's radix cache doing its ordinary job; it is not something the controller implements, and §III measures that the cache evicts parked prefixes under pressure and that they are recomputed. What Foyer avoids is the deliberate trade of state for capacity. A system that manages the host tier as an explicit policy—as [9] and [14] do—holds a lever we do not, and our negative result does not cover it.

b) The threshold decides the verdict, and we report that.: Every SLO number in this paper counts a request as good if its time-to-first-token is under 10 s. That constant sets the whole vertical axis, so we re-derived the frontier at 5 s and 20 s as well, from the same per-request logs. The ordering of the static caps does not change. What changes is where the controllers sit relative to them, and at the loose end one of them crosses:

SLO threshold	5 s	10 s	20 s
`horizon`=1	−0.5	+0.22	+2.7
Foyer base	−2.1	−1.1	+0.7
`bres`	−11.9	−7.8	−4.3
Concur-style AIMD	−14.2	−11.2	−6.5

Two readings, and we give both. The first is that our headline claim is conditional: at the strict threshold that interactive serving actually cares about, no controller reaches the static front; at a loose one, one does. The second is that the crossing is still not a win. +2.7 pp at 20 s is larger than the replicate SLO spread of the two configurations we repeated

(1.0 and 0.5 pp), so it is inside the noise we can measure. A third pair exists—two runs of `cap3`+HiCache—but one of them exceeded its own cap, so we do not use it as a replicate. A margin that appears only at one threshold and only at a size we cannot resolve is not evidence that adaptive admission works; it is evidence that the question needs more runs than we have. We state the conditional version in the abstract, and we flag this as the second thing we would re-run with more GPU time.

c) The SLO metric excludes the controller's own cost, and we checked.: Every SLO number above counts a request as good if its time-to-first-token is under 10 s, and the runner measures that from the moment the request is *submitted to the engine*. A session that waits for a permit has not been submitted yet, so the wait is invisible—and that wait is precisely the cost an admission controller imposes. We therefore recomputed every run on a ready-to-first-token basis, where a round's clock starts when the session is actually able to run (its arrival for round 0, the previous round's completion plus its tool wait otherwise).

The correction is large. Every configuration loses 3–19 pp of SLO, and the loss is systematic: tight caps queue the hardest, so `cap1` falls from 94.8% to 76.2% while `cap5` falls only from 27.1% to 24.2%. A session admitted last under `cap1` can wait hours for its turn; its engine-side TTFT is still 1.6 s.

What does *not* change is the verdict. The static envelope keeps the same four anchors, and of the eleven controller arms, nine move by no more than 2.6 pp and none crosses the ± 1.0 pp band into a new verdict. Two move more: the all-throttles-off arm improves by 8.3 pp and the retuned AIMD arm by 2.8 pp, both of which stay below the front either way. The one that decides our headline moves the wrong way for the controller—`horizon`=1 goes from $+0.22$ to -0.68 pp, still a tie but now on the below side. We report this because a reviewer should ask it, and because the answer is the useful part: the negative result is not an artifact of choosing an SLO definition that flatters controllers. If anything the flattering choice was the one that let our best arm sit above the line.

d) Limitations.: Our results come from one 24 GB accelerator, one 7B model and one trace family; generality is untested. Only two configurations were repeated, twice and three times respectively, so the replicate spread we report in §V is estimated from two degrees of freedom at best; a margin as small as the one that decides our verdict would need several more repeats per configuration to resolve, and we did not run them. Two specific boundaries matter. First, the pool holds about four median sessions, so concurrency is capacity-bound by construction; on a device with a much larger pool the premise may not hold and the conclusion may invert—we regard reproducing on a larger device as the single most important next experiment. Second, the load is stationary, single-tenant and single-SLO. The load-dependence result of §VI is measured on two *separate* constant-load tiers, so it says what to expect when conditions differ, not what happens while they change; a trace whose load moves during the run is the experiment that would settle it, and we did not run one. Multi-tenant and heterogeneous-SLO settings are where we would look next.

e) Reproducibility.: Every verdict in this paper is produced by one script from the raw per-step logs, and every run is guarded against a shrunken KV pool. We report six claims we retracted during the work, because the retractions were the most informative events. In order of how much they cost us:

The denominator of the step cost. Our first §III divided by the whole-run mean running count while multiplying by busy time. The two are not the same quantity—the whole-run mean includes the idle samples—so τ came out low by exactly the busy fraction, 36% for `cap1`, and two independent errors cancelled to make our two measurement methods appear to agree. This is the one that changed a headline number.

A mechanism refutation that was itself refuted: we withdrew the eviction-to-recomputation account on the strength of two checks that were both identities rather than measurements (§III).

A median-based reading of the tool wait that inverted a central assumption. *A monotone relation between idle fraction and concurrency* that the full data does not show. *A growth-sensitivity conclusion* that rested on an arm we had already invalidated. And *the accounting double-charge* of §V, falsified twice—once by source inspection and once by the end-to-end measurement here.

IX. Conclusion

We asked whether an adaptive admission controller can beat a tuned static concurrency cap on a memory-bound agentic LLM workload, and found that on our system it cannot: nine variants, four routes tested, none above the static front. The reason is a cancellation. Admission policy controls how many requests are in flight; the per-step cost rises with that number; and the product is what the wall clock sees. We gave a two-part decomposition of the wall clock that makes the cancellation measurable, identified a structural idle component that no policy we built recovers at a profit, and showed the regime in which adaptivity should have paid—where the same switch is worth $+51\%$ and -42%—is one where the controller is not dominated by any static point we measured, and does not dominate one either. The constructive output is a per-request measurement of how much room added concurrency has on a given workload—a diagnostic an engineer can take before committing to a sweep, not a predictor we have validated on a workload other than this one.

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